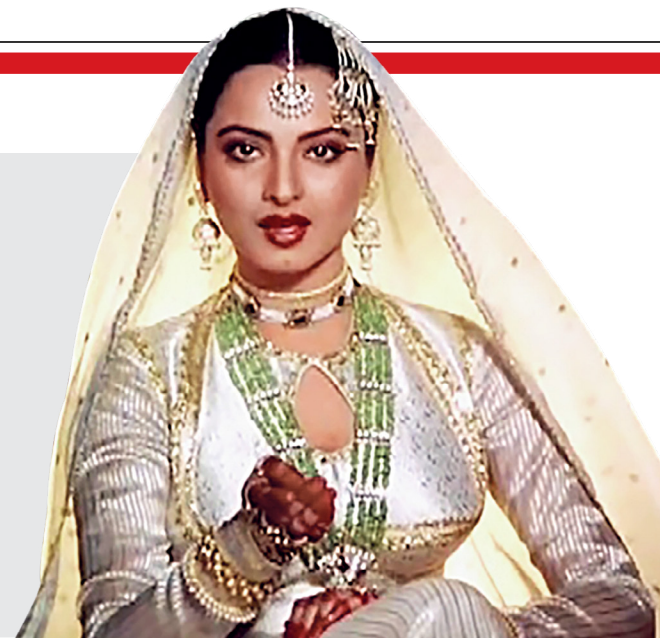
In Aankhon Ki Masti

***Umrao Jaan* (1981)**

Asha Bhosle, Kathak dancer-choreographer Kumudini Lakhia and the incomparable Rekha at their sublime best. When this mujra played in single-screen theatres, women filled the afternoon shows and admired and applauded every close-up of Rekha. Shot and staged beautifully by director Muzaffar Ali, it's an ode to *shringar rasa*. The teasing, the build-up, the reveal...it's everything a memorable dance should be.





Dholi Taro Dhol Baaje

***Hum Dil De Chuke Sanam* (1999)**

Garba, in all its glorious revelry, in a mainstream Hindi film. Sanjay Leela Bhansali's mother, Leela, taught the garba...so no wonder. He ropes in husband-wife duo Samir and Arsh Tanna as well as Vaibhavi Merchant for this opulent choreography. Arsh, fresh from maternity, was unwilling, but submitted to Bhansali and Aishwarya Rai—and a special vanity van! The purity of the folk style carried over so blazingly well, it fetched a National Award (and begat a national craze). In Gujarati, they say, '*Chaggana hai*'...it has to climax. The *Dholi Taaro* crescendo does exactly that.

Bindiya Chamkegi / I Love You

***Do Raaste* (1969)/ *Mr India* (1987)**



A lilting Pilu-based Punjabi folk air fills the terrace as Mumtaz distractingly woos her studious beau (Rajesh Khanna). A rare setting for romance—lovers in Hindi films usually chose locales far from the limiting confines of the house. Seduction, affection, respect, acceptance...all of it comes together beautifully with, yes, the chiffon sari that became a recurrent motif in Hindi films. In a very different song 16 years later, Sridevi in *Mr India* offered just two commonalities: chiffon and cult status. She understood what Shekhar Kapur and Saroj Khan wanted and gave more than could be articulated.



Ek Do Teen

***Tezaab* (1988)**

A path-breaking song, and a deceptively difficult one—with intricate steps plotted by Saroj Khan, mixing *mela* ground folk with hip hop. Madhuri Dixit had to rehearse for nearly two weeks before she was ready for the shoot. I remember travelling with the actress to the US for a show and as soon as we got off the flight, the organiser said she had to get on stage in hours and perform the song—and she said she couldn't. The song that made Madhuri a dancing star on par with Sridevi was no walk in the park!